Food of the seventy-two seasons

WORKING GLOSSARY / FRUIT · VEGETABLES · FISH & SEAFOOD



128 foods consolidated from 235 source labels in currently cached season letters. Every listed fruit, vegetable, and fish has a name, a short food note, and season cross-reference. Food identities, Japanese spellings, and catalogue-derived notes need editorial and source review before print.

54 ITEM STUDIES / TWO ON EACH OF 27 CATEGORY PAGES

DESIGN PROOF / IMAGE SUBJECTS AND COPY UNVERIFIED

Fruit

Akebi

木通 · あけび

akebi / KŌ 38

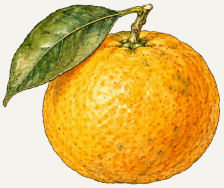
A wild vine fruit with pale lavender skin that cracks to reveal translucent, seed-studded flesh tasting faintly of honeydew and lychee, the soft interior is eaten fresh while the bitter rind is stuffed with miso-seasoned meat and fried.

01 Amanatsu orange

甘夏 · あまなつ

amanatsu / KŌ 21, 22, 25, 26, 27, 28

Harvested in winter but left to mellow until April or May, amanatsu trades sharpness for a honeyed acidity, its thick pith still carrying enough pleasant bitterness to wake the palate.



01 / Amanatsu orange



02 / Apple

02 Apple

林檎 · りんご

ringo / KŌ 56

Japanese apples arrive large and impeccably crisp, their flesh shattering cleanly under the teeth with a spray of juice that carries both sweetness and a faint wine-like depth.

Black soybean pickles

黒豆漬け · くろまめずけ

kuromame-zuke / KŌ 54

Glossy black soybeans simmered until tender, then steeped in sweetened soy until each bean holds a lacquered sheen and faint molasses depth.

Blueberry

ブルーベリー

burūberī / KŌ 36, 37, 39

Japanese blueberries grown in highland orchards reach their sweetest point in July and August, their skins taut with a bloom of pale dust that smudges at the touch.

Fruit



01 / Cherry

01 Cherry

桜桃 · さくらんぼ

sakuranbo / KŌ 24, 28, 29, 30, 31, 32, 33, 35

These are not the ornamental cherries of hanami but eating varieties, Satonishiki with their heart-shaped bodies yielding flesh that snaps clean and sweet against the teeth.

Chinese quince

花梨 · かりん

karin / KŌ 55

Too hard and astringent to eat raw, the golden karin is prized for its intoxicating fragrance, a honeyed sweetness that fills winter rooms when placed in a bowl.

02 Early peach

早桃 · はやもも

hayamomo / KŌ 33

The first peaches of the season arrive smaller and firmer than their midsummer kin, their flesh yielding a clean, almost floral sweetness that carries a whisper of tartness near the stone.



02 / Early peach

Early pear

早生梨 · わせなし

wase nashi / KŌ 40

These first nashi of the season arrive with flesh so crisp it shatters against the teeth, their juice running clear and faintly honeyed before the deeper sweetness of later harvests develops.

Early persimmon

早柿 · はやがき

hayagaki / KŌ 50

These first persimmons of the season arrive while summer's heat still lingers, their flesh firm and crisp rather than the jammy softness of later varieties, a clean sweetness with faint astringency at the edges.

Fruit

01 Fig

無花果 · いちじく

ichijiku / KŌ 47, 49

The flesh yields to the teeth in a way that feels almost liquid, honey-sweet with a faint graininess from the countless tiny seeds within.



01 / Fig

Grape

葡萄 · ぶどう

budō / KŌ 41, 42

Japanese grapes arrive heavy on the stem, their skins slipping free to reveal flesh so sweet it borders on floral, varieties like Kyoho and Shine Muscat prized for size, fragrance, and that first cold bite.

Green plum

青梅 · あおうめ

aoume / KŌ 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30, 31, 32, 34, 35

Hard, astringent, and intensely fragrant, green plums arrive too sour to eat raw, their flesh meant instead for transformation into umeshu liqueur or the salt-preserved umeboshi that will sustain appetites through humid months ahead.



02 / Japanese pear

02 Japanese pear

梨 · なし

nashi / KŌ 41, 42, 43, 44, 46, 47, 50, 52, 53, 54

Unlike its Western cousins, nashi offers a crisp, granular flesh that shatters between the teeth with a spray of cool, faintly floral juice, refreshment distilled into fruit form.

Japanese plum

李 · すもも

sumomo / KŌ 36

Smaller and rounder than its Western cousins, the sumomo offers flesh that ranges from honey-gold to deep crimson, with a tartness at the skin that yields to syrupy sweetness near the stone.

Fruit



01 / Kabosu

01 Kabosu

香母酢 · かぼす

kabosu / KŌ 48

A golf ball-sized citrus from Ōita Prefecture, kabosu yields a juice more rounded than sudachi, less bitter than lemon, its pale green flesh releasing an aroma somewhere between bergamot and fresh-cut grass when squeezed over grilled sanma.

Koshu grape

甲州葡萄 · こうしゅうぶどう

kōshū budō / KŌ 54

Japan's indigenous wine grape, cultivated in the foothills of Mount Fuji for over a millennium, with translucent pink-bronze skin that yields flesh of gentle sweetness and a faint mineral finish.

Kosui pear

幸水 · こうすい

kōsui / KŌ 49

The first major nashi of the season, Kōsui arrives with flesh so crisp it shatters against the teeth, releasing juice that tastes of honey touched with the faintest citrus acidity.

Kurinameshi pear

栗南水 · くりなめし

kurinameshi / KŌ 56

A newer nashi cultivar bred for exceptional sweetness and dense, fine-grained flesh that shatters cleanly between the teeth, its juice running clear as spring water.

02 Kyoho grape

巨峰 · きょほう

kyohō / KŌ 46, 47, 52

These dark purple grapes slip from their skins with a gentle squeeze, revealing translucent flesh so sweet and musky it perfumes the fingers.



02 / Kyoho grape

Fruit

Late strawberry

晩生苺 · ばんせいいちご

bansei ichigo / KŌ 24

These final strawberries of the season arrive smaller and deeply flushed, their sugars concentrated by warming days into an almost jammy intensity that the pale spring berries never achieve.

01 Loquat

枇杷 · びわ

biwa / KŌ 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30, 32, 33, 34, 35

Beneath its thin, downy skin lies flesh the color of apricot preserve, yielding, faintly tart, with a floral sweetness that vanishes almost as quickly as it arrives.



01 / Loquat

Mango

マンゴー

mangō / KŌ 30, 36, 39

Miyazaki's Taiyo no Tamago mangoes arrive with flesh so dense and perfumed it yields like custard beneath the knife, their skin blushing from green to sunset red.



02 / Mikan

02 Mikan

晩生みかん · ばんせいみかん

bansei mikan / KŌ 21

These late-ripening satsuma mandarins have thicker skins and denser flesh than their autumn cousins, their sweetness deepened by months of winter chill into something almost honeyed.

Mountain yam bulbil

零余子 · むかご

mukago / KŌ 55

These thumbnail-sized aerial tubers form where leaf meets stem on the wild yamanoimo vine, their thin russet skin yielding to a faintly sticky, nutty flesh when roasted in their jackets with coarse salt.

Fruit



01 / Muscat grape

01 Muscat grape
マスカット
masukatto / KŌ 38, 44, 49, 53

Japanese Shine Muscat grapes yield to the teeth with a crisp snap, their translucent jade flesh releasing a perfume somewhere between lychee and white flowers, eaten skin and all, no seeds to interrupt the pleasure.

Nijisseiki pear
二十世紀梨 · にじっせいきなし
nijisseiki nashi / KŌ 45, 48, 51

A thin-skinned pear with jade-pale flesh so crisp it shatters between the teeth, releasing a flood of juice sweet as spring water.

Passion fruit
パッションフルーツ
passhon furūtsu / KŌ 40

Cut crosswise, the wrinkled purple shell reveals a glistening cavity of black seeds suspended in translucent golden pulp, intensely aromatic, at once tart and honeyed, with a fragrance that fills the room.

02 Persimmon
柿 · かき
kaki / KŌ 47, 51, 52, 53, 54, 55, 56

The hachiya variety yields to gentle pressure when perfectly ripe, its flesh collapsing into a honey-thick pulp that tastes of dates and brown sugar with a faint tannic whisper.



02 / Persimmon

Pione grape
ピオーネ
pīone / KŌ 43, 44, 45, 46, 48, 49, 50, 51

A cross between Kyoho and Cannon Hall Muscat, Pione yields berries the size of small plums with blue-black skin that slips away to reveal translucent flesh of startling sweetness and faint musk.

Fruit

01 Plum

プラム

puramu / KŌ 37, 39

These Western-style plums arrive with flesh that yields to the tooth in a single clean give, their skins taut and blushed from deep garnet to pale gold, each variety balancing tart snap against honeyed sweetness.



01 / Plum

Prune plum

西洋李 · せいようすもも

seiyō sumomo / KŌ 34

These oval European plums arrive with flesh that yields to honey-sweetness, their skins carrying that particular dusty bloom that rubs away under the thumb.

Ripe plum

完熟梅 · かんじゅくうめ

kanjuku ume / KŌ 33

These are ume left on the branch until they blush gold and yield to gentle pressure, their flesh now fragrant with apricot-like sweetness rather than the sharp green astringency of earlier pickings.

Shine Muscat grape

シャインマスカット

shain masukatto / KŌ 45, 48, 50, 51

A seedless grape with skin so thin it yields without resistance, releasing flesh that tastes of muscat perfume and white honey.



02 / Strawberry

02 Strawberry

苺 · いちご

ichigo / KŌ 21, 22, 23, 25, 26, 27

Japanese strawberries are bred for delicate sweetness and tender flesh, varieties like Amaou and Tochiotome prized for their fragrance and jewel-like appearance on white porcelain.

Fruit



01 / Sudachi

01 Sudachi

酢橘 · すだち

sudachi / KŌ 40, 43, 52, 53, 56

A small citrus no larger than a golf ball, prized not for its flesh but for its intensely aromatic rind and bracingly sour juice, a few drops transform grilled sanma or matsutake soup with bright, clean acidity.

Summer orange

夏蜜柑 · なつみかん

natsu mikan / KŌ 22, 23

A thick-skinned citrus with segments that pull apart in uneven petals, its juice bracingly acidic with a faint honeyed finish that arrives only after months of patience on the branch.

Watermelon

西瓜 · すいか

suika / KŌ 29, 31, 32, 34, 35, 37, 38, 41, 42

These early specimens arrive smaller and denser than their midsummer cousins, their flesh a concentrated pink with a crispness that yields cleanly to the teeth.

White peach

白桃 · はくとう

hakutō / KŌ 31, 36, 37, 38, 39, 40, 41, 42, 43, 44, 45, 46

Cradled in foam nets at fruit shops, these pale beauties yield flesh so tender it bruises at a glance, their perfume filling a room before the first bite releases floods of honeyed juice.

02 Wild mountain grape

山葡萄 · やまぶど

yamabudo / KŌ 55

These small, intensely flavored grapes grow wild on vines that climb forest trees, their deep purple-black clusters yielding a juice so tart and concentrated it stains the tongue.



02 / Wild mountain grape

Vegetables

Ashitaba

明日葉 · あしたば

ashitaba / KŌ 26

A coastal herb from the Izu Islands whose thick stems weep golden sap when cut, the flavor sits between celery and angelica, with a faint medicinal bitterness that tempura transforms into something almost sweet.

01 Bamboo shoot

筍 · たけのこ

takenoko / KŌ 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 27

Dug at dawn before the sun can turn their sugars bitter, fresh takenoko have a faint sweetness and a texture that yields with a clean snap, nothing like the pallid canned version.



01 / Bamboo shoot

Bitter melon

苦瓜 · にがうり

nigauri / KŌ 38, 40, 43

The warted jade skin yields to a spongy, pale interior whose bracing bitterness cuts through the humidity like a cold cloth on the neck.



02 / Burdock root

02 Burdock root

牛蒡 · ごぼう

gobō / KŌ 56

A slender, earth-colored root with bark-rough skin and flesh that oxidizes to pale rust the moment it meets air; prized for its dense, almost meaty chew and faint sweetness that emerges after long simmering.

Vegetables



01 / Butterbur

01 Butterbur

蕗 · ふき

fuki / KŌ 22, 23

Pale green stems with a mineral bitterness that lingers clean on the tongue, their hollow centers ideal for simmering in dashi until the fibers turn silken.

Chrysanthemum greens

春菊 · しゅんぎく

shungiku / KŌ 51, 52, 55, 56

These serrated leaves carry a bracing, almost medicinal bitterness and a floral musk that cuts through rich broths, the reason they appear in hot pots just as the first real chill settles in.

Corn

玉蜀黍 · ともろこし

tomorokoshi / KŌ 36

Freshly harvested ears possess a milky sweetness that fades within hours of picking, the kernels so tender they burst against the teeth with grassy, almost floral notes.

02 Cucumber

胡瓜 · きゅうり

kyūri / KŌ 31, 37

Japanese cucumbers arrive slender and thin-skinned, their flesh dense with a grassy sweetness that shatters cleanly between the teeth, nothing like their waterlogged Western cousins.



02 / Cucumber

Edamame

枝豆 · えだまめ

edamame / KŌ 33, 34, 35, 40, 46

Young soybeans harvested still clinging to the branch, their pods furred with fine hairs that hold the morning dew; bite through and the beans slide out with a faint sweetness, tasting of green growth and salt.

Vegetables

01 Eggplant

茄子 · なす

nasu / KŌ 29, 31, 32, 36

The skin turns glossy purple-black, stretched taut over cream-colored flesh that collapses into silk when grilled over charcoal.



01 / Eggplant

Fava bean

空豆 · そらまめ

soramame / KŌ 21, 23, 24, 25, 27, 28

Called 'sky beans' for the way their pods point upward on the stem, these legumes arrive with a fleeting sweetness and grass-green fragrance that disappears within days of harvest.

Ginkgo nut

銀杏 · ぎんなん

ginnan / KŌ 48, 50, 52, 53, 55

These jade-green kernels hide beneath a notoriously pungent flesh, their flavor somewhere between chestnut and edamame with a faintly bitter, almost resinous finish.



02 / Green pea

02 Green pea

青豌豆 · あおえんどう

ao-endō / KŌ 26

Freshly shelled peas possess a sweetness that fades within hours of harvest, their sugars converting to starch even as you carry them home.

Green pepper

ピーマン

piiman / KŌ 37

Summer-harvested specimens have thin, yielding walls and a clean vegetal bitterness that children famously protest and adults come to crave, char them quickly over high flame until the skin blisters and the flesh turns silken.

Vegetables

Green shiso

青紫蘇 · あおしそ

aoshiso / KŌ 33, 35, 47

The jagged leaves release their unmistakable fragrance only when torn or bruised, a sharp, almost mentholated freshness that cuts through the heaviness of raw fish and summer heat.

Green yuzu

青柚子 · あおゆず

aoyuzu / KŌ 34

Harvested unripe, green yuzu offers a sharper, more herbaceous bite than its mature form, the zest bright with volatile oils that sting the nose pleasantly when grated over warm dishes.



01 / Japanese pepper leaf

01 Japanese pepper leaf

山椒 · さんしょう

sanshō / KŌ 23

These young leaves carry a bright, almost electric tingle on the tongue, with a citrus-pine fragrance that cuts through rich dishes like simmered bamboo shoot or grilled eel.

Japanese wild parsley

三つ葉 · みつば

mitsuba / KŌ 24, 49

Three-lobed leaves on hollow stems carry a fragrance somewhere between celery and angelica, bright and faintly peppery, releasing their scent the moment they meet hot broth.

02 Kabocha

南瓜 · かぼちゃ

kabocha / KŌ 43, 45, 46, 47

A dense-fleshed winter squash with dry, chestnut-like sweetness and skin tender enough to eat, the flesh turns almost jam-thick when simmered in dashi and soy.



02 / Kabocha

Vegetables

01 Lotus root

蓮根 · れんこん

renkon / KŌ 38, 45, 49, 51, 53

Cut crosswise, the wheel reveals its lace of air pockets, a pattern read as 'seeing clearly into the future,' making it essential to New Year's osechi.



01 / Lotus root

Maitake

舞茸 · まいたけ

maitake / KŌ 45

Found clustered at the base of old oaks and chestnuts, maitake unfolds in rippling bronze-gray fronds with an earthy fragrance and a texture that stays toothsome whether grilled with a brush of soy or torn into tempura batter.



02 / Malabar spinach

02 Malabar spinach

蔓紫 · つるむらさき

tsuru-murasaki / KŌ 41, 44

A climbing vine whose thick, glossy leaves release a gentle mucilage when cooked, lending a cooling slip to summer dishes that cuts through the season's heaviness.

Manganji pepper

万願寺とうがらし · まんがんじとうがらし

manganji tōgarashi / KŌ 35, 43

A long, thick-fleshed sweet pepper from Maizuru, Kyoto, virtually without heat, its skin blisters and chars beautifully over flame, releasing a green sweetness that tastes of summer rain on warm soil.

Vegetables



01 / Matsutake mushroom

01 Matsutake mushroom

松茸 · まつたけ

matsutake / KŌ 48, 49, 50, 51, 52, 53, 54

Found beneath fallen needles in ancient pine groves, this dense-fleshed mushroom releases a scent like cinnamon and cypress that no other fungus possesses, sliced thin and grilled over charcoal, it needs only a whisper of sudachi citrus.

Molokhia

モロヘイヤ

moroheiya / KŌ 39, 42

An Egyptian mallow whose dark, almost jade leaves release a silken mucilage when chopped, thickening soups with a vegetal richness that clings to the spoon.

Mountain vegetables

山菜 · さんさい

sansai / KŌ 22, 27

A collective term for wild edibles foraged from mountain and woodland, fiddlehead ferns, butterbur buds, fatsia shoots, each carrying its own bright bitterness that wakes the palate from winter's heaviness.

02 Myoga ginger

茗荷 · みょうが

myōga / KŌ 29, 30, 31, 32, 33, 34, 35, 36, 39, 41, 42, 43, 44, 46

These pale pink torpedo-shaped buds carry a bright, resinous sting that cuts through the heaviness of humid days, sliced thin, they shatter against cold sōmen or float in clear soup.



02 / Myoga ginger

Myōga shoot

茗荷竹 · みょうがたけ

myōgatake / KŌ 28

These blanched young stems of the myōga ginger plant emerge before the familiar flower buds, offering a milder, more delicate bite, crisp as celery, faintly perfumed, often sliced thin for clear soups or dressed simply with miso.

Vegetables

01 Mōi cucumber

モーウィ

mōi / KŌ 44

A pale, thick-skinned heirloom cucumber from Okinawa with crisp, almost melon-like flesh that stays cool and firm even in brutal subtropical heat.



01 / Mōi cucumber

Napa cabbage

白菜 · はくさい

hakusai / KŌ 54

Broad, pale leaves with crisp white ribs that turn silken when braised, their flavor deepening to a subtle sweetness after the first hard frost transforms their starches.



02 / New garlic

02 New garlic

新大蒜 · しんにんにく

shin ninniku / KŌ 28

Harvested young, new garlic offers a mild sweetness and moisture absent from cured heads, the cloves almost creamy when roasted whole, without the sharp bite that builds through storage.

New ginger

新生姜 · しんしょうが

shin shōga / KŌ 24, 25, 26

Pale as winter moonlight with tips blushed pink, new ginger arrives with flesh so delicate and fibers so fine it can be sliced tissue-thin and eaten raw, its heat bright but fleeting on the tongue.

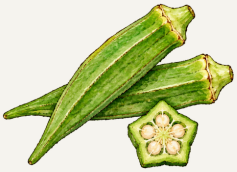
New potato

新じゃが · しんじゃが

shin-jaga / KŌ 27, 30

Harvested before their skins have set, new potatoes possess a waxy, almost translucent flesh and a sweetness that dissipates within days of digging.

Vegetables



01 / Okra

01 Okra

オクラ

okura / KŌ 36, 37, 40

Cut crosswise, each pod reveals a perfect five-pointed star, its mucilaginous threads binding dashi and soy into something cool and slippery against the August heat.

Perilla

紫蘇 · しそ

shiso / KŌ 29, 30, 31, 32, 34, 38, 40

Each leaf carries a bright, almost mentholated sharpness that cuts through the humidity of rainy season, wrap one around a bite of sashimi and the fish tastes cleaner, cooler.

Purple sweet potato

紫芋 · むらさきいも

murasaki-imo / KŌ 54

A dense, dry-fleshed sweet potato whose violet flesh deepens to near-indigo when steamed, yielding a chestnut-like sweetness with faint wine notes.

Rakkyo

辣韮 · らっきょう

rakkyō / KŌ 29, 30

These small, ivory bulbs, somewhere between shallot and garlic in pungency, are harvested just as humidity settles over the archipelago, their crisp bite a natural foil for rich summer dishes.

02 Shimeji mushroom

占地 · しめじ

shimeji / KŌ 47, 48, 50, 51, 53, 55

These tight clusters of slender stems and small brown caps carry a faint bitterness that sweetens only with heat, releasing an umami depth prized in nabemono and takikomi gohan.



02 / Shimeji mushroom

Vegetables

01 Shishito pepper

獅子唐 · ししとう

shishitō / KŌ 44, 45, 46

Named for the wrinkled tip that resembles a lion's head, these thin-walled peppers blister quickly in hot oil, collapsing into tender pockets of grassy sweetness with an occasional surprising bite of heat, perhaps one in ten carries real fire.



01 / Shishito pepper

Silk pod pea

絹さや · きぬさや

kinusaya / KŌ 28

These flat, edible-podded peas earn their name from the silken sheen of their pale green skin, so thin it seems to hold light.



02 / Spring cabbage

02 Spring cabbage

春キャベツ · はるきゃべつ

haru kyabetsu / KŌ 21, 25, 26

Unlike the tight, pale heads of winter, spring cabbage arrives with leaves so tender they tear like wet paper, their sweetness bright enough to eat raw with nothing but a drift of salt.

Summer daikon

夏大根 · なつだいこん

natsu daikon / KŌ 33

Unlike the mild, sweet daikon of winter, summer daikon carries a peppery sting that cuts through humid days, grated raw, it becomes a cooling condiment with real presence.

Sweet corn

玉蜀黍 · とうもろこし

tōmorokoshi / KŌ 39, 42

Harvested at dawn and rushed to market, the kernels still hold their milk-sweet juice, bite through the taut skin and the sugars haven't yet begun their slow turn to starch.

Vegetables

Sweet potato

薩摩芋 · さつまいも

satsumaimo / KŌ 47, 50

Freshly dug sweet potatoes need weeks of curing before their dense, chestnut-like flesh develops the honeyed sweetness that caramelizes at the edges of a stone-roasted imo.



01 / Taro

01 Taro

里芋 · さといも

satoimo / KŌ 48, 49, 52, 54, 55, 56

The flesh yields to the teeth with a dense, almost glutinous give, its surface faintly slick from mucilage that speaks of the wet paddies where it grew.

Tomato

蕃茄 · とまと

tomato / KŌ 37

At peak ripeness, the flesh gives way to a balance of sweetness and faint acidity, the skin still warm from the afternoon heat.

Turnip

蕪 · かぶ

kabu / KŌ 56

The Japanese turnip is smaller and more delicate than its Western counterpart, with skin so thin it need not be peeled and flesh that turns silken when simmered in dashi.

02 Udo

独活 · うど

udo / KŌ 21

A tall, celery-pale stalk with a flavor caught between asparagus and fennel, prized for its crisp bite and faint bitterness that speaks of wild places.



02 / Udo

Vegetables

Wakame

若布 · わかめ

wakame / KŌ 22

Freshly harvested wakame has a silken texture and bright mineral sweetness that fades within hours of leaving the sea, nothing like its dried counterpart.

Water spinach

空芯菜 · くうしない

kūshinai / KŌ 39, 42

Named for its hollow stems that stay crisp even after a flash in the wok, this Southeast Asian green thrives in Japan's muggy July and August, offering a texture between spinach and morning glory vine.

01 Winter melon

冬瓜 · とうがん

tōgan / KŌ 38, 41

Despite its name suggesting winter, this pale gourd reaches its prime in July and August, its translucent flesh turning almost glass-like when simmered in dashi, cooling the body from within.



01 / Winter melon

Yard-long bean

十六ささげ · じゅうろくささげ

jūroku sasage / KŌ 41

Named for the sixteen seeds that line each slender pod, these beans snap with a grassy sweetness and cook to a silken texture that green beans cannot match.



02 / Young corn

02 Young corn

とうもろこし

tomorokoshi / KŌ 32

Harvested before the kernels fully set, young corn offers a milky sweetness and tender cob you can eat whole, the silk still pale, the husk tight with morning dew.

Fish & seafood

01 Abalone

鮑 · あわび

awabi / KŌ 39

The muscular foot, sliced thin against its grain, yields a clean brine and a crunch that softens to velvet, prized raw as sashimi or barely kissed by steam.



01 / Abalone

Atka mackerel

ほっけ

hokke / KŌ 54

A fish of the northern seas, hokke yields pale, fatty meat that caramelizes beautifully when dried and grilled, its edges crisping while the flesh stays moist and faintly sweet.

Beltfish

太刀魚 · たちうお

tachiuo / KŌ 42

Named for its resemblance to a Japanese sword, the tachiuo is a ribbon of silver that swims vertically in deep waters, its flesh turning translucent and sweet as autumn deepens.



02 / Bonito

02 Bonito

鰹 · かつお

katsuo / KŌ 24, 25

The first bonito of the season, called hatsugatsuo, arrives lean and clean-fleshed, its deep red meat best eaten as tataki, seared over straw fire until the edges char while the center stays cool and raw.

Fish & seafood

Chicken grunt

伊佐木 · いさき

isaki / KŌ 28, 34, 35

A handsome striped fish whose flesh reaches its richest state just before spawning, firm yet yielding, with a clean sweetness that needs only salt and flame.



01 / Conger eel

01 Conger eel

穴子 · あなご

anago / KŌ 31, 32, 33, 34, 35, 36, 37, 38, 39, 40

Unlike its richer cousin unagi, anago offers a delicate, almost ephemeral sweetness, its pale flesh turning silky when simmered in a light soy broth or brushed with nikiri and torched atop sushi.

Filefish

皮剥 · かわはぎ

kawahagi / KŌ 43, 55

A fish whose rough, sandpaper skin must be stripped away to reveal meat so clean and mild it borders on sweetness, its liver swelling rich and creamy as waters chill.

02 Firefly squid

蛍烏賊 · ほたるいか

hotaru ika / KŌ 23

These thumb-sized squid rise from deep waters to spawn, their photophores glowing an ethereal blue-white, eaten whole, their bodies burst with a briny sweetness and faint bitterness from the viscera.



02 / Firefly squid

Fish & seafood

01 Flounder

鰈 · かれい

karei / KŌ 24

A flatfish whose paper-thin sashimi reveals an almost translucent sweetness, the meat gaining density and fat as winter deepens.



01 / Flounder



02 / Freshwater clam

02 Freshwater clam

蜆 · しじみ

shijimi / KŌ 41

These small, dark-shelled clams yield a broth of surprising depth, faintly sweet, touched with iron, the color of weak tea.

Gizzard shad

小鰭 · こはだ

kohada / KŌ 46

A slender silver fish whose skin shimmers with an iridescent blue-green sheen, kohada is prized for its delicate balance of rich oils and clean brine, the vinegar cure of edomae sushi tradition draws out its brightness without masking the sea.

Goby

鯊 · はぜ

haze / KŌ 54

A small, bottom-dwelling fish with translucent flesh that turns pure white when cooked, prized for its clean sweetness and delicate texture in tempura, the batter barely there, the fish tasting of cold river and sea meeting.

Fish & seafood



01 / Golden-eye snapper

01 Golden-eye snapper

金目鯛 · きんめだい

kinmedai / KŌ 51, 56

A deep-sea fish with luminous crimson skin and large golden eyes, prized for flesh that turns silken and sweet when simmered in soy and ginger.

Greater amberjack

間八 · かんぱち

kanpachi / KŌ 47

Named for the dark band between its eyes that forms the kanji for 'eight' (□), kanpachi yields flesh that is leaner and more delicate than its buri cousins, pale pink, with a clean sweetness and subtle crunch when sliced for sashimi.

Grunt

石鯛 · いしだい

ishidai / KŌ 26, 27

The striped beakfish, called ishidai for its habit of crushing shellfish against stones, yields firm white flesh with a clean mineral sweetness prized in sashimi and usuzukuri.

02 Halfbeak

鱵 · さより

sayori / KŌ 21, 22

A slender, silver-blue fish whose translucent flesh carries the faintest sweetness, prized for sashimi that gleams like morning light on still water.



02 / Halfbeak

Fish & seafood

01 Horse mackerel

鯵 · あじ

aji / KŌ 24, 25, 26, 27, 30, 33, 34, 38, 42, 44, 45

A silvery fish with a distinctive lateral line of bony scutes, its flesh now carries the clean, faintly sweet fat that comes before the humid months, best eaten as tataki, seared just at the edges, or in sashimi so fresh the meat still has tension.



01 / Horse mackerel

Icefish

白魚 · しらうお

shirauo / KŌ 21, 22, 23

These slender, glass-clear fish arrive when winter loosens its grip, their flesh so translucent you can see the dark thread of their spines.

Japanese sea bass

鱸 · すずき

suzuki / KŌ 28, 29, 35, 36, 37, 41, 42, 44, 50

A fish that changes names as it grows, seigo, fukko, then finally suzuki, its flesh at summer peak is clean and sweet, firm enough to hold its shape in usuzukuri slices yet yielding a delicate fat that blooms on the tongue.



02 / Japanese tiger prawn

02 Japanese tiger prawn

車海老 · くるまえび

kuruma-ebi / KŌ 43, 45

Named for the striped wheel-like pattern that curves along its shell, this prawn offers flesh that is sweet, firm, and faintly translucent, prized raw as odori, still quivering, or graced by the lightest tempura batter.

Fish & seafood



01 / Japanese whiting

01 Japanese whiting

鱚 · きす

kisu / KŌ 28, 29, 30

A slender, silver-skinned fish whose flesh is so delicate and clean-tasting it seems to dissolve on the tongue, the definitive tempura fish, its light sweetness heightened by a whisper-thin batter.

Mackerel

鯖 · さば

saba / KŌ 51, 53

The autumn mackerel carries a stripe of silver-blue iridescence and flesh so rich with oil it glistens when sliced for shimesaba.

Mahi-mahi

鰄 · しいら

shiira / KŌ 46

A muscular, iridescent fish whose firm white flesh takes well to the grill, yielding a clean sweetness with none of the heaviness of fattier catches.

02 Octopus

蛸 · たこ

tako / KŌ 36

Summer tako yields firm, resilient flesh with a clean sweetness that snaps between the teeth, boiled just until the skin turns that distinctive burgundy, sliced thin for sunomono or simmered tender in oden.



02 / Octopus

Olive flounder

鮃 · ひらめ

hirame / KŌ 55

A left-eyed flatfish prized for its translucent white flesh, served as usuzukuri, slices so thin they reveal the pattern of the plate beneath, each piece offering a clean, faintly sweet resistance to the teeth.

Fish & seafood

01 Pacific saury

秋刀魚 · さんま

sanma / KŌ 43, 44, 45, 46, 47, 48, 49, 50, 51, 52, 53, 56

A slender, silver-blue fish whose belly fat reaches its richest point as September nights grow crisp, grilled whole over charcoal until the skin blisters and crackles, eaten with a squeeze of sudachi and grated daikon to cut the oils.



01 / Pacific saury

Pike conger

鱧 · はも

hamo / KŌ 31, 32, 37, 39, 41

A serpentine eel prized in Kyoto despite the sea being hours away, its flesh stays firm in summer heat, and skilled knife work transforms hundreds of hairline bones into something that blooms like a white flower when blanched.

Salmon

鮭 · さけ

sake / KŌ 48, 52, 53

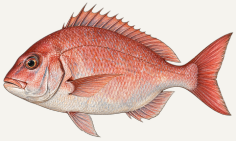
Wild salmon arriving in autumn carry the deep coral flesh and clean fat of fish that have journeyed thousands of miles to spawn.

Sardine

鰯 · いわし

iwashi / KŌ 30, 47

The silvery skin flashes blue-green like oil on water, and the meat beneath runs dark and rich with the fat that will carry the fish through lean months.



02 / Sea bream

02 Sea bream

鯛 · たい

tai / KŌ 21, 48, 49

The firm, translucent flesh carries a clean sweetness that intensifies as spawning season approaches, the skin crisping to a burnished rose when salt-grilled.

Fish & seafood

Skipjack tuna

戻り鰹 · もどりがつお

modori-gatsuo / KŌ 49, 50

The returning run yields flesh rich with fat from months of feeding in northern seas, deep crimson, almost burgundy, with a sweetness that needs only a whisper of ginger and ponzu.



01 / Spanish mackerel

01 Spanish mackerel

鰆 · さわら

sawara / KŌ 22, 23, 52, 54, 55, 56

A long, silver-blue predator whose flesh turns from pale coral to creamy white when salted overnight and grilled until the skin blisters and chars at the edges, releasing oils that taste of the sea's own sweetness.

Squid

烏賊 · いか

ika / KŌ 40

The flesh of summer squid is firm yet yielding, its sweetness clean as sea spray, best shown in sashimi cut so thin light passes through.

02 Sweetfish

鮎 · あゆ

ayu / KŌ 25, 26, 27, 29, 31, 32, 33, 38

A slender river fish whose flesh carries the faint fragrance of watermelon and fresh cucumber, the scent of clean mountain streams translated into protein.



02 / Sweetfish

Yellowtail amberjack

鰤 · ぶり

buri / KŌ 40

The winter buri, called kan-buri, carries ribbons of rich fat between its rosy flesh, each slice gleaming with an almost sweet unctuousness that coats the tongue.

Season key

CANONICAL KO IDS / APPROXIMATE START DATES

01 Water parsley flourishes
芹乃栄 01/05 · winter

02 Springs thaw beneath the ice
水泉動 01/10 · winter

03 Pheasants start to call
雉始雊 01/15 · winter

04 Butterburs bud
款冬華 01/20 · winter

05 Ice thickens on streams
水沢腹堅 01/25 · winter

06 Hens start laying eggs
鶏始乳 01/30 · winter

07 East wind melts the ice
東風解凍 02/04 · spring

08 Bush warblers start singing in the mountains
黄鶯睍睆 02/09 · spring

09 Fish emerge from the ice
魚上氷 02/14 · spring

10 Rain moistens the soil
土脈潤起 02/19 · spring

11 Mist starts to linger
霞始靆 02/24 · spring

12 Plants sprout, trees bud
草木萌動 03/01 · spring

13 Hibernating insects emerge
蟄虫啓戸 03/06 · spring

14 First peach blossoms open
桃始笑 03/11 · spring

15 Caterpillars become butterflies
菜虫化蝶 03/16 · spring

16 Sparrows start nesting
雀始巣 03/21 · spring

17 First cherry blossoms
桜始開 03/26 · spring

18 Distant thunder
雷乃発声 03/31 · spring

19 Swallows arrive
玄鳥至 04/05 · spring

20 Wild geese fly north
鴻雁北 04/10 · spring

21 First rainbows appear
虹始見 04/15 · spring

22 First reeds sprout
葭始生 04/20 · spring

23 Last frost, rice shoots sprout
霜止出苗 04/25 · spring

24 Peonies bloom
牡丹華 04/30 · spring

DATES VARY SLIGHTLY BY YEAR / GLOSSARY REFERENCES SOURCE LETTERS

Season key

CANONICAL KO IDS / APPROXIMATE START DATES

25 Frogs start calling
蛙始鳴 05/06 · summer

26 Earthworms emerge
蚯蚓出 05/11 · summer

27 Bamboo shoots appear
竹笋生 05/16 · summer

28 Silkworms feast on mulberry leaves
蚕起食桑 05/21 · summer

29 Safflowers bloom
紅花栄 05/26 · summer

30 Wheat ripens and harvest begins
麦秋至 05/31 · summer

31 Praying mantises hatch
螳螂生 06/06 · summer

32 Decaying grass becomes fireflies
腐草為蛍 06/11 · summer

33 Plums turn yellow
梅子黄 06/16 · summer

34 Self-heal withers
乃東枯 06/21 · summer

35 Irises bloom
菖蒲華 06/26 · summer

36 Crow-dipper sprouts
半夏生 07/02 · summer

37 Warm winds arrive
温風至 07/07 · summer

38 Lotus blossoms open
蓮始開 07/12 · summer

39 Young hawks learn to fly
鷹乃学習 07/17 · summer

40 Paulownia trees bear first seeds
桐始結花 07/23 · summer

41 Humid heat soaks the earth
土潤溽暑 07/28 · summer

42 Heavy rains sometimes fall
大雨時行 08/02 · summer

43 Cool winds arrive
涼風至 08/07 · autumn

44 Evening cicadas sing
寒蝉鳴 08/12 · autumn

45 Thick fog descends
蒙霧升降 08/17 · autumn

46 Cotton flowers open
綿柎開 08/23 · autumn

47 Heaven and earth begin to cool
天地始粛 08/28 · autumn

48 Rice ripens in the fields
禾乃登 09/02 · autumn

DATES VARY SLIGHTLY BY YEAR / GLOSSARY REFERENCES SOURCE LETTERS

Season key

CANONICAL KO IDS / APPROXIMATE START DATES

49 Dew glistens white on grass
草露白 09/08 · autumn

50 Wagtails start to sing
鶺鴒鳴 09/13 · autumn

51 Swallows depart
玄鳥去 09/18 · autumn

52 Thunder falls silent
雷乃収声 09/23 · autumn

53 Insects seal their dens
蟄虫坏戸 09/28 · autumn

54 Water begins to dry up
水始涸 10/03 · autumn

55 Wild geese arrive from the north
鴻雁来 10/08 · autumn

56 Chrysanthemums bloom
菊花開 10/13 · autumn

57 Crickets chirp around the door
蟋蟀在戸 10/18 · autumn

58 First frost falls
霜始降 10/23 · autumn

59 Light rains sometimes fall
霎時施 10/28 · autumn

60 Maple and ivy turn yellow
楓蔦黄 11/02 · autumn

61 Camellias start to bloom
山茶始開 11/07 · winter

62 Earth begins to freeze
地始凍 11/12 · winter

63 Daffodils bloom and perfume the air
金盞香 11/17 · winter

64 Rainbows hide
虹蔵不見 11/22 · winter

65 North winds blow away the leaves
朔風払葉 11/27 · winter

66 Tachibana citrus starts to ripen
橘始黄 12/02 · winter

67 Skies close and winter sets in
閉塞成冬 12/07 · winter

68 Bears retreat to their dens
熊蟄穴 12/12 · winter

69 Salmon gather and swim upstream
鰤魚群 12/17 · winter

70 Self-heal sprouts anew
乃東生 12/22 · winter

71 Deer shed their antlers
麋角解 12/27 · winter

72 Wheat sprouts under the snow
雪下出麦 01/01 · winter

DATES VARY SLIGHTLY BY YEAR / GLOSSARY REFERENCES SOURCE LETTERS